while, before falling back with the last two remaining tanks of 7 Cavalry towards Chaku, which they reached by last light.

At Chaku, 1 Sikh LI was hardly a reassuring sight. Recalls Darshan Khullar: ‘When in the late afternoon, I reached Chaku, I learnt that a halt had been ordered in the withdrawal. 1 Sikh LI was occupying the feature or rather the lower slopes just above the road. It was no defensive position; they simply sat around because they had no digging implements, only their rifles and brens, weapon scales of ammunition and two 3.7 inch mountain guns.

‘…There was no order. People sat listlessly around in groups, with about 20-odd vehicles lined up on the road. Only some enterprising persons, and I was among them, carried some rations. Kapila and I collected some scrap wood and lit a fire and were rewarded by being eased out of it by the arrival of the brigade commander, CO 1 Sikh LI and a couple of others including his Sapper company commander. There was some futile talk of sending for some digging implements and anti-personnel mines. We went back to the so-called gun position by the roadside. It was a starlit night and bitterly cold.’

Besides 1 Sikh LI, the remnants of 6/8 GR were also at Chaku. Shortly after midnight, sentries posted on the lookout reported that the Chinese were advancing towards Chaku from Rupa as they could see a few hundred men on the move with mashals (torches). Accordingly, an officer knocked on the door of the basha in which Gurbax Singh was sleeping to apprise him of this new development. M. S. Brar, the commanding officer of 1 Sikh LI was furious at being woken up for what he considered a trivial matter. Convinced that the mashals were being carried by our own tribals, the colonel wanted to know if the Chinese would be so stupid as to advance down the road carrying torches, and that too in their hundreds.

Official history again is very kind to this officer, attributing the defence of Chaku to him. At 3.45 a.m., when the mashal-lit party opened up with machine guns and tracer bullets streamed through the darkness towards the Indian positions, it started an immediate haphazard exodus. Overall, 1 Sikh LI got away with relatively few casualties—it had sixteen missing, twenty-two killed and thirty-five wounded.

Commanded by Lieutenant Colonel G. S. Kale, 6/8 GR was the last Indian battalion to be thrown into the Kameng Frontier Division. It had only come into contact with the Chinese less than twenty-four hours earlier at